Only in one matter did the Amir refuse to co-operate with the British. Macnaghten repeatedly urged him to visit Shah Shuja, but Dost Mohammad flatly refused, and even sent back the trays of food that the Shah had sent to his surrendered rival – a mortal insult in the Afghan honour system. According to Mirza 'Ata, 'the Amir angrily replied to Macnaghten's entreaties, "It is enough that I have come to see you with the result that I am to be taken abroad a prisoner. What would I gain from going to see one who has brought this storm of misfortune on his country? Without the King, you English could never independently have entered Afghanistan."'[104] Fayz Mohammad puts a similar speech into the Amir's mouth: 'I have no business with Shah Shuja,' he is supposed to have said to Macnaghten. 'I have not come to offer an oath of allegiance to him.' Macnaghten insisted, 'In view of the concern for the state that he has, it would be appropriate for you to see him.' The Amir replied, 'It is you who have put him on the throne, not the great mass of those who "loose and bind". If this is true, then you should cease propping him up. When you do, it will be clear to you and to other intelligent people which man deserves to be sovereign and whom the leaders of the country and the subjects will obey. If he has anything to say to me let him come forward and state it in your presence.'[105]

The refusal of the British to hand Dost Mohammad over to the Sadozais for execution caused Shuja huge offence. For weeks he had been urging Macnaghten to send assassins to have the Amir killed, and now at the very least he expected his old enemy to be blinded. But Macnaghten refused even to discuss the matter. 'His Majesty was surprised and could not understand why Dost Mohammad Khan rudely chose not even to pay his respects at court,' wrote Mohammad Husain Herati. 'All the Amir's adherents and followers and Barakzai relatives who remained in Afghanistan went about their business as freely as if they had been infidels just converted to Islam and washed free of sin! The extreme attention and favour paid by the English to the faction and clan of Dost Mohammad Khan led very quickly to a total loss of prestige of His Majesty, as if he had fallen, hard, from heaven to earth.' Meanwhile, continued Herati, 'Macnaghten's efforts to please his guest, and his neglect of the rights of His Majesty, led at length to his own death: again, as the poet said: "If you shower favours on bad men, you harm the good and virtuous."'[106]